ing, and training is totally different."

"It wasn't easy, it was hard," he adds with a laugh. "But I had to do it."

Early on, Singh appeared in a wrestling tag team with fellow Indian Saurav Gurjar—a former actor famous for his role as Bheem in the 2013 *Mahabharat* TV series. More recently, Singh resurfaced in his current avatar, Veer Mahaan—the Great Warrior—clad in his lungi, greeting opponents with a namaste before roaring past them.

Professional wrestling—and especially the WWE—has been popular among Indian audiences for decades. Even though it is technically not a 'sport', WWE programmes are among the most viewed shows on Indian sports channels, trailing only cricket and kabaddi. In return, the WWE has featured a handful of Indian-origin superstars in the past, including The Great Khali (Dalip Singh Rana) and Jinder Mahal (Yuvraj Singh Dhesi). Rinku Singh will hope that Veer can become the next, steady big name on that list.

"Eventually, it's going to lead into a good place," he says. "Maybe bring the championship belt all the way back to India. Maybe go against [legendary pro wrestlers] Brock Lesner or Roman Reigns, because that's what our Indian fans have been wanting to see."

For now, Singh will continue to grow his brand, to tackle this latest career choice, to continue to make his father proud. He recalls how close he became to his father after his mom passed away, how much he started to learn about his father's journey. "I would ask him, 'What's it like to be in Superman mode? I'm pretty sure you felt tired, you felt like quitting? What kept you going?' His answer was, 'You. You guys kept me going.'"

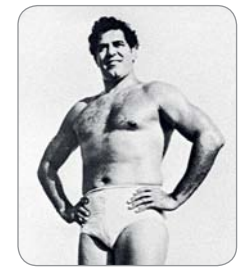
Now, Singh looks through the Zoom screen, an athlete on the cusp of another major achievement. "You're asking me what keeps *me* going? It's my father, my country, my pride. There are so many reasons I have in life." ■

- Karan Madhok

Wrestler Mania

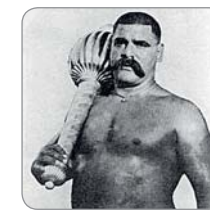
India pro wrestlers who have ruled the ring

TIGER JEET SINGH: For over 20 years, Tiger performed in Japan's wrestling circuit, where he was famous for rushing the ring with a sword in his mouth



DARA SINGH: The Godfather of Indian pahalwans, Dara Singh Randhawa was known for his dominance of Asian pro wrestling circuits, including iconic performances in the 1950s against the likes of Lou Thesz, King Kong Czaya, George Gordienko and more

THE GREAT GAMA: A.k.a. Ghulam Mohammad Baksh Butt and Rustam-e-Hind, Gama was one of the first Indians to make it on the international show wrestling circuit (in 1910)



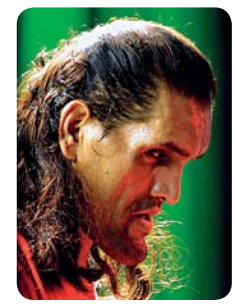


TIGER ALI SINGH: Tiger Jeet's son, Tiger Ali performed for New Japan Pro-Wrestling Dojo before his breakthrough to the WWF in the late 1990s

SATNAM SINGH BHAMARA: Bhamara made basketball history in 2015 as the first Indian to be drafted into the NBA. In 2021, he traded slam dunks for body slams when he signed with All Elite Wrestling (AEW)



MAHABALI SHERA & 'RING KA KING': In 2011, Impact Wrestling (previously known as TNA) held a novel pro wrestling competition in India, 'Ring Ka King', where Mahabali Shera (Amanpreet Singh Randhawa) was crowned World Heavyweight Champion



THE GREAT KHALI: Former bodybuilding 'Mr India' winner Dalip Singh Rana performed in various wrestling circuits before becoming a WWE star. He's the first Indian to win the WWE's World Heavyweight Championship belt



KAVITA DEVI: The first-ever Indian woman in the WWE, the former weightlifter and power-lifter from Haryana became a pro-wrestler in 2016

SANGA: Actor Saurav Gurjar—famous for playing Bheem in 2013's *Mahabharat* series—made his start at 'Ring Ka King' and later joined the WWE

JINDER MAHAL: Entering the ring in a turban and sherwani, the Indo-Canadian (nephew of Gama Singh) leant heavily into his Punjabi heritage. He won the WWE Championship belt in 2017

